



Office of Public Affairs
U.S. Department of Justice



Justice Department Surpasses \$12 Billion in Compensation to Crime Victims Since 2000

Friday, April 11, 2025

For Immediate Release

Office of Public Affairs

To commemorate the 2025 National Crime Victims' Rights Week, the Department of Justice reaffirms its steadfast commitment to compensate crime victims with federally forfeited assets. The Justice Department's Asset Forfeiture Program has surpassed \$12 billion in compensation to crime victims.

In fiscal year 2024 and the beginning of fiscal year 2025 alone, more than \$735.3 million has been returned to victims of human trafficking; romance, investment, and healthcare fraud; business email compromise and government imposter schemes; drug diversion; and cryptocurrency-related thefts and frauds.

"This extraordinary milestone demonstrates the effectiveness of the Asset Forfeiture Program in taking the profit out of crime and compensating victims," said Matthew R. Galeotti, Head of the Justice Department's Criminal Division. "While the Criminal Division is deeply proud of these efforts, we recognize that crime victims often lose much more than money. We hope that victims, from exploited children to older Americans targeted by sophisticated criminal schemes, can move forward in their recovery through this compensation. This milestone was made possible by the Justice Department's Money Laundering and Asset Recovery Section, which manages the Asset Forfeiture Program, U.S. Attorneys' Offices across the country, and the many federal, state, local, and tribal law enforcement agencies that have dedicated their time and resources to these investigations."

Recent cases in which victims were compensated for their losses with forfeited assets in 2024 or 2025 include:

\$4.3 Billion to Victims of Bernie Madoff

United States v. Bernard L. Madoff (Southern District of New York)

In December 2024, the Justice Department announced that the Madoff Victim Fund (MVF) would make its 10th and final distribution of over \$131.4 million to victims of the Bernard L. Madoff fraud scheme. These funds were forfeited by the U.S. government in connection with the Bernard L. Madoff Investment Securities LLC (BLMIS) fraud scheme. Through its 10 distributions, MVF paid over \$4.3 billion from forfeited funds to 40,930 victims in 127 countries for losses they suffered from the collapse of BLMIS, bringing recovery for victims to nearly 94% of their fraud loss. According to court documents and information presented in related proceedings, for decades, Madoff used his position as chairman of Bernard L. Madoff Investment Securities LLC, the investment advisory business he founded in 1960, to steal billions from his clients. On March 12, 2009, Madoff pleaded guilty to 11 federal felonies, admitting that he had turned his wealth management business into the world's largest Ponzi scheme, benefitting himself, his family, and select members of his inner circle.

\$420 Million to Victims of Fraud Schemes Facilitated by Western Union

United States v. The Western Union Company (Middle District of Pennsylvania)

In 2017, Western Union entered into a deferred prosecution agreement (DPA) with the United States. Pursuant to the DPA, Western Union acknowledged responsibility for its criminal conduct, which included violations of the Bank Secrecy Act and aiding and abetting wire fraud. Western Union agreed to forfeit \$586 million, which has been made available to compensate victims of the international consumer fraud scheme through the remission process. Western Union simultaneously resolved a parallel civil investigation with the Federal Trade Commission. To date, the Criminal Division has disbursed more than \$420 million to approximately 175,000 victims.

\$8 Million Returned to Victims of Email Business Compromise Scams

United States v. Olalekan Jacob Ponle (Northern District of Illinois)

Olalekan Jacob Ponle worked with co-schemers to engage in numerous business email compromise schemes. The co-schemers used phishing links to gain unauthorized access to email accounts and then created false instructions directing employees of the victim companies to wire money to bank accounts opened by money mules at Ponle's direction. After unwitting employees wired money, in some cases millions of dollars, to the bank accounts, Ponle instructed the money mules to convert the proceeds to Bitcoin and send them to him. As a result of Ponle's scheme, victim companies suffered more than \$8.03 million in actual losses. The government seized the Bitcoin, obtained a final order of forfeiture, liquidated the cryptocurrency, and used the proceeds to compensate the victims of Ponle's fraud.

\$5.6 Million to the Small Business Administration

United States v. Aydin Kalantarov, et al. (Northern District of Ohio)

According to court documents, from May 2020 through October 2020, Aydin Kalantarov, along with his two brothers, Zaur Kalantarli and Ali Kalantarli, conspired to defraud the U.S. Small Business Association (SBA) of nearly \$7 million in Economic Injury Disaster Loans (EIDL). As part of the scheme the brothers created 70 fictitious Ohio corporations with agriculture sounding names. Once the fictitious corporations

were created, the brothers submitted fraudulent EIDL loan applications to the SBA claiming that their business was adversely affected by the pandemic. The SBA funded 47 of the applications for a total of approximately \$7 million. \$5.6 million in forfeited funds was transferred to the clerk of the court for payment to the SBA.

\$2.28 Million Returned to Victims of Two Business Email Compromise Schemes

United States v. Contents of TD Bank Account, Account Ending 7684, Held in the Name of O'Shane K. Malcolm, et al. (District of Connecticut)

United States v. Contents of Truist Bank Account Ending 5792, Held in The Name of Quest Freight LLC (District of Connecticut)

In the first scam, criminal actors compromised an email account associated with a member of the management team of a city's Board of Education. In June 2023, these actors created a fake email account that mimicked the email of a bus company that held a contract with the Board of Education for bussing. Using the fake bus company email address, the criminal actors then were able to change the bus company's payment information from the real bus company to an account held by the criminal actors, and the city sent approximately \$5.9 million dollars to the account. The government successfully seized and forfeited approximately \$1,187,691 of the stolen money, which was returned to the city through remission.

The second forfeiture action involved a healthcare company that was a victim of a business email compromise (BEC) attack. In April 2023, the company's yearly medical malpractice insurance payment was set to be paid. Shortly before the due date, the company received a fraudulent email, purportedly from its malpractice insurance company, with new wire instructions. The company sent approximately \$1,652,254 via a wire transfer using the newly provided instructions. The government successfully seized and forfeited approximately \$1,100,694 remaining in the account, which was returned to the healthcare company through remissions.

\$328,500 to an Elderly Victim of a Computer Support Scam

United States v. Discovery Bank Account Ending in 2237 (District of Connecticut)

According to court documents, in February 2024, an elderly woman who was tricked by a computer support scheme that mimicked Microsoft customer support transferred approximately \$550,000 to the scammers in two wire transfers. Within two days of the transfers, the victim and a family member reported the incident to a local police department, who then partnered with Homeland Security Investigations (HSI) to investigate the crime. Fortunately, one of the wire transfers, in the amount of \$221,000, was reversed by the bank and returned to the victim. HSI traced the remaining money, totaling approximately \$328,573, and seized it. The U.S. Attorney's Office then filed a civil asset forfeiture action to forfeit the money to the government, and the U.S. Attorney's Office and HSI then worked with the Department of Justice's Money Laundering and Asset Recovery Section to return the money to the victim.

\$6.4 Million to the Internal Revenue Service

United States v. Michael Little (Middle District of Florida)

From 2019 to 2021, Michael Little filed a series of false tax returns claiming massive, bogus fuel tax credits. He filed the false returns in his own name and in the names of co-conspirators and identity theft victims. As a result of this scheme, Little and his co-conspirators obtained at least \$12.3 million in fraudulent tax refunds and attempted to obtain at least \$27 million more. Little and his co-conspirators also conspired to launder their ill-gotten gains and used significant portions of the fraudulent tax refunds to purchase real estate and other assets. Over \$6.4 million in forfeited funds were transferred to the clerk of court for payment to the IRS.

\$52,000 to a Survivor of Human Trafficking

United States v. Thuy Tien Luong (Western District of North Carolina)

Thuy Tien Luong was convicted of forced labor and ordered to serve 15 years in prison for compelling the labor of one of her nail technicians at a salon she owned and operated. From October 2016 to June 2018, Luong forced the survivor's labor by, among other things, physically assaulting the survivor, threatening to ruin the survivor's reputation with her family, and falsely claiming that the survivor owed Luong a fictitious debt. In addition to resulting in the return of funds seized from Luong to the Clerk of Court to pay the survivor, the case also resulted in the return to the survivor of a seized bracelet that Luong had held as "payment" towards the survivor's fictitious debt.

\$6.3 Million Returned to Estate Victims of an Embezzlement Scheme

United States v. Richard J. Sherwood, et al. (Northern District of New York)

Starting in 2006, Richard J. Sherwood and Thomas K. Lagan provided estate planning and related legal services to Capital Region philanthropists Warren and Pauline Bruggeman, and to Pauline's sister, Anne Urban, all of Niskayuna, New York. They were advising the Bruggemans when, in 2006, the Bruggemans signed wills directing that all their assets go to churches, civic organizations, a local hospital, and a local university scholarship fund, aside from bequests to Urban and Julia Rentz, Pauline's sisters.

Warren Bruggeman died in April 2009, and Pauline died in August 2011. In each pleading guilty, Sherwood and Lagan admitted that they conspired to steal, and did steal, millions of dollars from Pauline Bruggeman's estate as well as from the estate of Urban, who died in 2013. The co-conspirators admitted that they stole \$11,831,563 and Sherwood also admitted that he transferred to himself the Bruggeman family camp located on Galway Lake, in Saratoga County.

For additional information about the Department of Justice's victim compensation program, please visit: [Criminal Division | Victims](#).

Updated July 24, 2025

Components

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Press Release Number: 25-376

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June 18, 2025



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